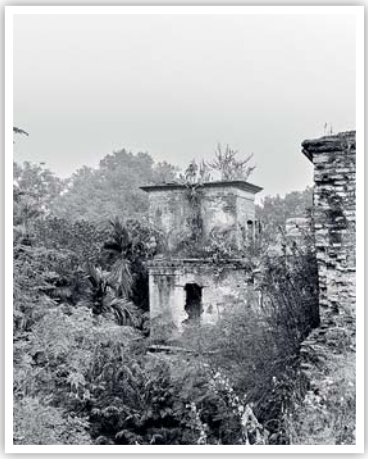






WHAT TIME LEFT BEHIND (Left) Sarker Protick's works from the series *Ruins* (2016-ongoing) and (below) a work from the series *Mr and Mrs Das* (2012-16)

ART

BRINGING THEN TO THE NOW

Photos of rural Bengal and ruins are a well-worn theme, but Sarker Protick's work again makes it new

NIROBODHI (TILL TIME STANDS STILL)
Sarker Protick
Shrine Empire, New Delhi
(Until November 11)

The ruins of a temple stand on a tiny island of earth in the middle of shallow-flooded paddy fields, like the wreck of some ancient rocket that failed to take off many centuries ago. Its pointed top pokes up into the misty winter morning and two of its four side spires are missing, like engines that might have fallen off. The recently irrigated fields are covered in a sheet of water in which the structure is reflected among the tufts of freshly planted rice. The contrast of old brickwork and the evidence of ongoing human activity asserts itself only after you have looked at the image for a while, as if two layers of time are peeling off each other in a decomposing palimpsest. There are other images of ruins in this series (titled *Jhirno*) that work similarly—ordinary and straightforward at first glance, but which then hook you into a longer engagement and meditation.

In terms of photographic images, rural Bengal and ruins are an old and well-worn visual pairing, but something in the way Sarker Protick frames and presents these images makes them quietly new and unsettling. The ghosts of David McCutchion as well as those of Bernd and Hilla Becher wander through these pictures, but without ever staying too long; Protick clearly shares some of McCutchion's emotional connection to Bengal's old masonry as he does the precise, held-in stillness of the Bechers' gaze, but here, in the compositions and sequencing, a very different kind of looking emerges—the